

Professional Skills I: Presenting Lecture Notes, Day 6

Main point of this session:

Make meaningful eye contact - using gazing to make eye contact with one member of the audience at a time, taking care to include folks at the edges of the audience, and not just the folks in the center. Speak in a conversational tone - use the mature part of your voice and engage the audience as you would a single listener, avoiding any quality of "reciting"

Learning objectives for today:

— Meaningful eye contact
— Conversational tone of speech
— Vocal highlighting

Designate a student to watch the time in class.

Meditation session (10 minutes)

Lie down

Stretch and get comfortable

Close your eyes, or keep them open if you prefer

Feel your breath...

Feel the ground beneath you supporting you...

Try to enter a state of embodiment, without interruption from the language-based, intellectual mind.

If a thought enters your mind, acknowledge it and let it go...

If any of your muscles are tense, try to relax them: relax your face, forehead, cheeks, jaw, ears, neck, shoulders, spine, arms, wrists, hands, fingers, stomach, legs, ankles, toes.

Now, if you've had your eyes closed, open them.

Let your eyes softly gaze around the room, noticing shapes, color, and texture...

Now find a spot on the wall or ceiling, and let your eyes rest there...

Notice the spot in exquisite detail...

Now let your eyes move around the room, noticing objects and shadows...

Now, very slowly, you can transition yourself from a lying-down position to a standing-up position

Review (5 minutes)

Concentration. Relaxation. Meaningful gesture. Home bases. Theatrical Sphere of Expression. Phrasing. Breathing during phrasing. Acting the behavior of thinking. Vocal variation: point of view, introspection / communication, vocal dynamics (pitch, rhythm and volume).

Don't reread the whole definition if they say something close to correct. Saves time.

[VII] Techniques for Public Speaking

Last week we learned how to express emotion on stage. Every one of you expanded your comfort zones way past where you might have thought possible. This week, we are bringing it together to give a technical presentation. The best technical presentations still tell a story. Acting thinking, taking point of view, and varying your voice to tell that story matters even in a technical speech. Everything we learned last week matters. This week, we will learn techniques specifically to make your technical presentations effective.

Conversational Tone (10 minutes)

Speak in a conversational tone - use the mature part of your voice and engage the audience as you would a single listener, avoiding any quality of "reciting"

Demo: mature part of voice ("Hello, today I'm going to tell you about a conversational tone") vs. higher register ("Hello! I'm going to give a presentation on how to give a presentation...")

Demo: it's as if I glance backwards to tell Andrii, completely frankly, "Hey Andrii, can you pass me the pita?" And then I resume the presentation with that same register. Boom!

Anyone want to practice coming up here (just one student)? Explain about what happened this morning. Feedback for this one student on conversational tone.

Meaningful Eye Contact (10 minutes)

Make meaningful eye contact - using gazing to make eye contact with one member of the audience at a time, taking care to include folks at the edges of the audience, and not just the folks in the center. Meaningful eye contact is not a glance. Hold for 2-3 seconds.

Demo: I'll use eye contact as I explain to you about how to use eye contact.

Anyone want to practice coming up here (just one student)? Explain about what happened this morning. Feedback for this one student on meaningful eye contact.

Activity (15 minutes)

Students pair up, read texts to each other one at a time in parallel (concentrating, relaxing, phrasing). Practice eye contact by looking into partner's eyes. Practice conversational tone. After one student reads, partner gives feedback. Then switch.

— BREAK (5 minutes) —

Vocal Highlighting (5 minutes)

Enunciate key terms and vocabulary words. Demonstrate vocal highlighting as I teach it!

Example: “**Vocal highlighting** means **stressing** certain words when you speak to make them stand out. It's like **bolding** words in speech so that people get the main point.”

Exercise (30 minutes)

Students stand up one by one, read their text (or describe their morning in detail if they don't have a text yet), practicing all basic techniques, conversational tone, meaningful eye contact, and vocal highlighting. I give feedback on these last three skills.

No need for detailed feedback from me. Students mostly need to practice. They will know what they need to do. They just might not be able to tell whether they are speaking conversationally, so I will tell them that.